

Operation Handwriting

Two-week whole-school handwriting intervention, Dar Al-Ulum Montreal

Duration: 10 school days, 60 minutes per day, same time slot every day. Grouping: by cycle. Cycle 1 (grades 1 and 2), Cycle 2 (grades 3 and 4), Cycle 3 (grades 5 and 6). Scripts: Cycle 1 works on print. Cycle 2 repairs print in the first two days, then builds cursive. Cycle 3 works on cursive fluency, speed and presentation. If a group already writes cursive fluently, or a Cycle 2 group has never seen cursive, the lead teacher moves the group one track up or down on Day 1 after the diagnostic. The tracks are in the teacher's guide.

Suggested dates: Monday 21 September to Friday 2 October 2026. Day 1 is a Monday so that the diagnostic and the post-test fall on the same weekday two weeks apart.

Language: every worksheet is letter-based, so it works in English and in French. Word banks in the materials file are given in both languages. The pre-test and post-test passage exists in both languages, each student does the test in the language of their main writing class.

1. Goal and success measure

Goal: every student leaves the two weeks with writing that a stranger can read at first glance, with letters formed correctly, sized consistently, sitting on the line and spaced properly.

Measure: every student writes the same test passage on Day 1 and on Day 10. Both samples are scored on the six-criterion rubric (24 points). The school target is an average gain of at least 6 points per cycle and no student below 12 points on Day 10. Students who score under 12 on Day 10 go onto a four-week follow-up list with 10 minutes of daily practice in their homeroom.

2. The daily hour, same shape every day, every cycle

Minutes	Block	What happens
0 to 5	Set-up and warm-up	Students get paper, pencil and the day's sheet. Posture check (feet flat, back straight, paper tilted, helper hand holds the page). Finger warm-up from the warm-up card.
5 to 15	Direct teaching	Teacher models the day's target on the board slowly, three times, saying the verbal pathway out loud. Students write it in the air with the whole arm, then on the desk with a finger, then once on the page while saying the pathway.
15 to 35	Guided practice	Worksheet of the day. Trace the grey models, then copy on the empty line, then write from memory. Teacher circulates and corrects grip, posture and formation, in that order.
35 to 50	Applied writing	Students copy the day's sentence or short passage on lined paper using today's target. From Day 7 on, part of this block is dictation.
50 to 57	Self-check and feedback	Student circles their best letter or word on the page and underlines the one they want to fix. Teacher gives one star and one wish per student in writing or verbally.
57 to 60	Tracker and clean-up	Student colours the day's box on their progress chart. Sheets go into the student's handwriting folder.

The 60 minutes are not negotiable and are not split across the day. The value of the program comes from concentrated daily repetition with immediate correction.

3. Ten-day sequence by cycle

Cycle 1 (grades 1 and 2), print

Day	Focus	Letters and skills	Worksheet
1	Diagnostic and the basics	Pre-test. Posture, tripod grip, paper position. Pattern strokes: vertical lines, circles, bumps, zigzags.	Pre-test sheet, Pattern sheet
2	Straight line family	l, i, t, and capitals L, I, T, H, E, F	Print sheet A
3	Round family (anticlockwise)	c, o, a, d, g, q	Print sheet B
4	Bump family (down, up and over)	r, n, m, h, b, p	Print sheet C
5	Tricky family	e, s, f, k, u, v, w, x, y, z, j	Print sheets D and E
6	Capitals and letter sizes	All capitals. Tall letters, small letters, tail letters.	Capitals sheets, Size sort sheet
7	Spacing and the line	Finger spaces between words, letters touching, every letter sitting on the baseline.	Spacing sheet
8	Words and sentences	Copying sentences with correct size and spacing. Numbers 0 to 9.	Sentence sheet 1, Numbers sheet
9	Dictation	Teacher dictates six short sentences, students write with everything learned.	Lined paper C1
10	Post-test and showcase	Post-test, compare with Day 1, best-work display, certificates.	Post-test sheet, Certificate

Cycle 2 (grades 3 and 4), print repair then cursive

Day	Focus	Letters and skills	Worksheet
1	Diagnostic and the basics	Pre-test. Posture, grip, paper tilt. Self-assessment: each student names their two worst habits from the checklist.	Pre-test sheet, Self-check sheet
2	Print repair	Letter size (tall, small, tail), sitting on the line, spacing. Every student rewrites their Day 1 sample cleanly in print.	Size and spacing sheet, Lined paper C2
3	Cursive entry and undercurve family	Entry stroke, exit stroke. i, u, w, t	Cursive sheet A
4	Loop family	e, l, h, k, b, f	Cursive sheet B
5	Round family	a, d, g, q, c, o	Cursive sheet C
6	Overcurve family	n, m, v, x, y, z	Cursive sheet D
7	Remaining letters and joins	r, s, p, j, then joining practice with two-letter and three-letter combinations	Cursive sheet E, Joins sheet
8	Cursive capitals	The capitals used most: A, B, C, D, E, F, G, H, I, J, K, L, M, N, O, P, R, S, T, W.	Cursive capitals sheets
9	Words, sentences, dictation	Copy a paragraph in cursive, then four dictated sentences.	Sentence sheet 2, Lined paper C2

10	Post-test and showcase	Post-test in the student's stronger script, compare with Day 1, certificates.	Post-test sheet, Certificate
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Cycle 3 (grades 5 and 6), fluency, speed and presentation

Day	Focus	Skills	Worksheet
1	Diagnostic and honest self-assessment	Pre-test. Students score their own sample with the rubric and pick three targets.	Pre-test sheet, Self-check sheet
2	Grip, pressure and posture reset	Pencil pressure test (too dark, too light), tripod grip, wrist position. Consistent letter size.	Size and spacing sheet
3	Slant and alignment	One consistent slant, every letter on the baseline, x-height letters all the same height.	Slant sheet
4	Spacing	Even spacing between letters, one letter-width between words, margins.	Spacing sheet
5	Cursive join repair	The difficult joins: o, v, w, b to the next letter, r and s in the middle of words. Students who write print only work on connecting size and rhythm instead.	Joins sheet
6	Capitals and numbers	Capital letters in cursive and print, number formation, dates and headings.	Cursive capitals sheets, Numbers sheet
7	Speed with legibility	Timed copying, one minute, three minutes, five minutes. Count legible words per minute.	Speed sheet
8	Dictation and note-taking	Teacher reads a passage at speaking pace, students write. Then a second pass to clean up.	Speed sheet, Lined paper C3
9	Presentation	Final copy of a paragraph: title, date, margins, paragraph indent, no crossing out.	Presentation sheet
10	Post-test and showcase	Post-test, compare with Day 1, best-work display, certificates.	Post-test sheet, Certificate

4. Roles

Principal: launches the program with staff, does a five-minute walk-through of every group on Days 1, 5 and 10, receives the scores sheet on Day 10 and the follow-up list.

Lead teacher per cycle: runs the daily hour, scores the pre-test and post-test, keeps the class tracking sheet, hands in the scores on Day 10.

Homeroom teachers of other subjects: during the two weeks, every written task in every subject is held to the handwriting standard. A messy page is handed back to be rewritten. This is what makes the gains stick.

Support staff or assistants: during the guided practice block, one extra adult per group works with the five weakest students at a separate table.

5. Materials per group

Printed from the materials folder before Day 1: one handwriting folder per student, the pre-test sheet and post-test sheet (one each per student), the daily worksheets for the cycle (one per student per day), a stack of the cycle's lined paper (at least 20 sheets per student), one progress chart per student, one class tracking sheet per teacher, one rubric per teacher, the warm-up card and the posture and grip poster for the wall, one certificate per

student.

Physical: sharpened HB pencils, no pens for Cycle 1 and 2, erasers, triangular pencil grips for students with a fist or thumb-wrap grip, a slant board or a thick binder for students who press too hard or hunch.

6. Data and reporting

Day 1: pre-test scored the same day, entered on the class tracking sheet. Day 5: teacher notes on the tracking sheet which students are not moving, they get the extra-adult table from Day 6. Day 10: post-test scored, entered, average gain per group calculated, sheet handed to the principal with the follow-up list.

The scores sheet gives the principal three numbers per cycle: average pre-test score, average post-test score, number of students still under 12. That is the whole report.

7. After the two weeks

Handwriting does not stay fixed on its own. Three things keep it: every subject teacher continues to return messy work for rewriting, each homeroom keeps five minutes of copying at the start of the first writing period of the day for the rest of the term, and students on the follow-up list get 10 minutes daily with the lead teacher for four weeks, then a re-test.

This program covers the Latin script used in English and French. Arabic script handwriting is a separate module and can run on the same daily structure with its own letter families.

